Traditional Chinese Medicine in Singapore

Fieldwork Findings from a
Singapore TCM Medicine Hall
(Hougang)

Field visit: 13 September 2026

1. Introduction & Fieldwork Context

- Site: Tong Keow Healthcare
  Block 809 Hougang Central, #01-170, Singapore 530809
  Since 1968, Original Shop in Toa Payoh

- Method: shop observation, photographs and a semi-structured staff interview (shop staff member)

- Focus: common herbs and products, soup therapies, customer profiles, sourcing and quality

- Aim: understand how TCM is used in everyday Singapore life

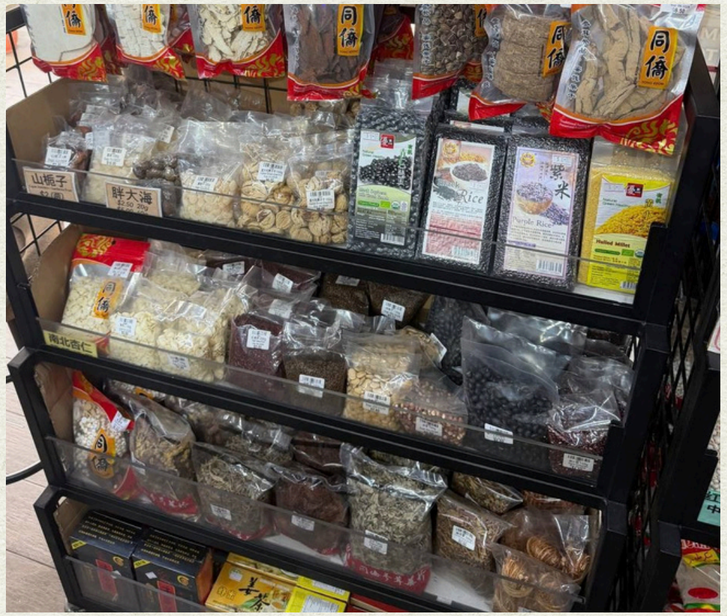
2. Best-Selling Herbs

1. Ginseng / American ginseng (人参／西洋参) – qi (气) and fatigue
2. Dang shen (党参) – qi (气) and digestion
3. Huang qi (黄芪) – qi (气) and immunity
4. Yu zhu (玉竹) – nourishing and moistening
5. Chinese yam (淮山) – spleen and digestion
6. Red dates (红枣) – everyday nourishment
7. Goji berries (枸杞) – general wellness
8. Monk fruit (罗汉果) – throat/lung comfort; popular in Singapore's hot weather

2. Popular Products

Frequently discussed product categories:

- Ginseng tonics (人参／西洋参) – fatigue and immunity
- Monk-fruit products (罗汉果) – throat/lung comfort and cooling
- Flower and herbal teas (花茶／凉茶) – convenient and popular with younger buyers
- Soup packs (药材汤包) – daily light nourishment
- Lingzhi supplements (灵芝保健品) – immune support
- Liver-care and mood-support products (养肝／疏肝解郁) – late nights and stress
- Yin Qiao-type remedies (银翘类) – colds
- Medicated oils (红花油／红油精) – aches and injuries, especially among older customers



3. Local Products

Singapore grows few medicinal herbs because the climate is less suitable, so local cultivation offers little advantage. Most raw materials come from China, which provides greater variety and generally lower prices.

Locally linked examples:

- Cactus (仙人掌) and roselle (洛神花)
- Patent medicines (中成药)
- Five flower and Luo Han guo teas (五花茶／罗汉果茶)

Many ingredients are imported, then processed and packaged in Singapore. Localisation therefore happens mainly through quality selection, preparation, packaging and convenience.

3. Soup Therapies

- Qing Bu Liang (清补凉)
- Dang Shen & Huang Qi - Qi Tonic Soup Pack(党参北芪补气汤)
- Yu Zhu & Huai Shan Moisturing Soup Pack(玉竹淮山润燥汤)
- Goji & Red Date Wellness Soup Pack (枸杞红枣养生汤)
- Five - Finger Fig Soup Pack (五指毛桃健脾汤)

3. Soup Therapies

Common soup combinations:

- Dang shen (党参) – qi (气), digestion and immunity
- Huang qi (黄芪) – qi (气) and daily strengthening
- Yu zhu (玉竹) – nourishing and moistening
- Chinese yam (淮山) – spleen and stomach support
- Red dates + goji (红枣＋枸杞) – nourishment and wellness

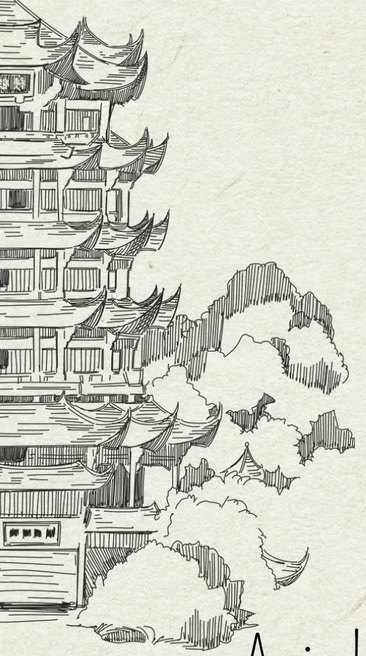
Without distinct four seasons, Singapore's hot, humid climate favours qing bu (清补; light nourishment), cooling soups and lung-moistening ingredients rather than strong tonics. Soup makes TCM part of ordinary family meals.

4. Less-Popular Products

The interview did not produce a verified bottom-three ranking. The clearest examples were:

- Ban zhi lian (半枝莲) – bought less often
- Specialist herbs that require combination with other ingredients
- Strong tonic formulas (大补方), which are less suited to Singapore's hot, humid climate

Low demand was linked to preparation effort, unfamiliarity and the need for guidance.



4. Medical Practices

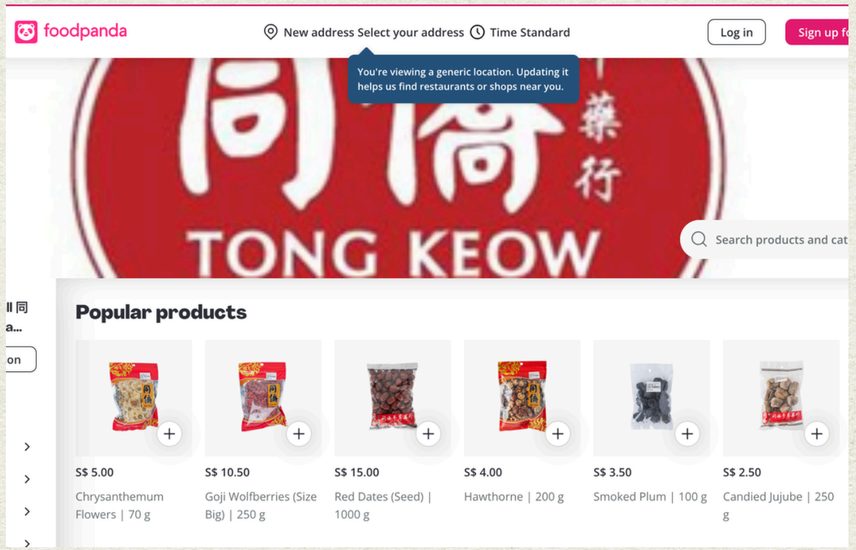
An in-house physician was not clearly confirmed. Staff described common symptom–remedy pairings:

- Colds – Yin Qiao-type remedies (银翘类)
- Diarrhoea – Huoxiang Zhengqi-type remedies (藿香正气类)
- Fatigue / qi deficiency (气虚) – ginseng (人参) or dang shen (党参)
- Lower immunity – Lingzhi and other supplements (灵芝保健品)
- Late nights, long work hours and stress – liver-care or mood-support products (养肝／疏肝解郁)
- Aches / injuries – red flower oil or Red Oil Essence (红花油／红油精), often bought by older customers

Professional diagnosis should be distinguished from self-selected retail remedies.

5. Analysis: TCM in Singapore

- Preventive care: TCM supports daily maintenance, not only illness.
- Generational pattern: customers are mainly middle-aged or older; younger buyers choose fewer raw herbs.
- Convenience shift: younger customers prefer teas, supplements and ready-made products.
- Local adaptation: ingredients are largely imported from China, then selected, processed and packaged locally.
- Lifestyle pressures: long work hours, phone use, late nights and stress create demand for liver-care, mood-support and immunity products.
- Cultural reach: Chinese customers dominate; Malay customers often buy dessert ingredients, while Indian customers often buy nuts.
- Trust and quality: the shop prioritises sulphur-free herbs, fresh colour and visible freshness.



6. Conclusion

1. TCM remains embedded in everyday food, wellness and family care.
2. Singapore favours light tonics, soup packs and convenient products.
3. Imported ingredients are locally adapted through processing and packaging.
4. Local TCM products try to accommodate modern needs, such as safety, taste, and side-effect concerns. It especially caters to the younger generation and people of all races.

Our field visit to Tong Keow shows how traditional practices can fit into daily routines in Singapore.

THANK YOU